ENGINEERING ETHICS CASE STUDY

Quality of Product & Business Decisions

Navigating the boundary between professional ethical canons and commercial management strategy.

Case 61-1 Analysis

MARKET BACKGROUND

The Commercial Dilemma

Market Pressure

Competitors introduced lower-quality products at reduced prices, driving down ABC Company's sales.

Management Response

Engineers were instructed to redesign the product for lower production cost under the existing brand name.

CORE DILEMMA

The Engineer's Obligation

> "Do engineers have an ethical duty to protest or refuse to design a lower-quality product under an established brand name?"

Concern: Using the established brand name for a downgraded product could mislead the public.

ETHICAL FRAMEWORK

Scope of Professional Canons

Safety & Health Boundary

If lower quality jeopardizes public safety or health, Canon 4 strictly requires engineers to notify management.

Commercial Jurisdiction

Product grade and pricing are commercial business decisions for management, outside the scope of engineering canons.

FINAL RULING

Conclusion & Professional Role

- **Advise Internally:** Engineers may express concerns regarding public perception through standard internal channels.
- **Corporate Accountability:** Adverse public reaction to quality drop impacts company reputation, not professional standing.
- **No Interference:** Extending ethics canons to block purely commercial choices would inappropriately disrupt business operations.